

CASTE SYSTEM: STRUCTURE AND CONTEMPORARY DYNAMICS

LEVEL OF ANALYSIS → FOUR FEATURES AND THEIR → MARRIAGE RULES THAT OPERATE → MOBILITY STRATEGIES → DOMINANT CASTE TEST → CASTE AND CLASS

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g2 and all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00

LEVEL OF ANALYSIS

LEVEL OF ANALYSIS

FOUR-FOLD TEXTUAL IDEAL TYPE, NORMATIVE

LOCAL ENDOGAMOUS BIRTH GROUP, OBSERVABLE

NARROWER ENDOGAMY CIRCLE INSIDE A JATI

ANSWER AT THE JATI LEVEL, ARGUE WITH THE VARNA

MUST REMEMBER

CASTE JOINS VARNA IDEOLOGY, LOCALLY RANKED JATIS, ENDOGAMY, HEREDITARY

CORE CLAIM	MECHANISM	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
VARNA → four-fold textual ideal type, normative	SUB-JATI → narrower endogamy circle inside a jati	MUST REMEMBER: Caste joins varna ideology, locally ranked jatis, endogamy, hereditary occupation, purity-pollution, social closure and power
JATI → local endogamous birth group, observable	RULE → answer at the jati level, argue with the varna template	Sanskritisation, dominant caste, secularisation, politicisation and caste-class mobility explain change without implying disappearance.

CORE CLAIM

VARNA → four-fold textual ideal type, normative

JATI → local endogamous birth group, observable

MECHANISM

SUB-JATI → narrower endogamy circle inside a jati

RULE → answer at the jati level, argue with the varna template

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

MUST REMEMBER: Caste joins varna ideology, locally ranked jatis, endogamy, hereditary occupation, purity-pollution, social closure and power

Sanskritisation, dominant caste, secularisation, politicisation and caste-class mobility explain change without implying disappearance.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → answer at the jati level, argue with the varna template.

01

STAGE 01

FOUR FEATURES AND THEIR RATE OF CHANGE

FOUR FEATURES AND THEIR RATE OF CHANGE

MOST CONSISTENTLY OBSERVED, CHANGES LEAST

LOCALLY RANKED BY PURITY AND POLLUTION

HEREDITARY MEMBERSHIP

FIXED BY BIRTH

OCCUPATION LINK

WEAKEST JOINT, BROKEN BY URBAN WORK

CORE CLAIM	MECHANISM	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
ENDOAMY → most consistently observed, changes least	HEREDITARY MEMBERSHIP → fixed by birth	ENDOAMY → most consistently observed, changes least
HIERARCHY → locally ranked by purity and pollution	OCCUPATION LINK → weakest joint, broken by urban work	HIERARCHY → locally ranked by purity and pollution

CORE CLAIM

ENDOAMY → most consistently observed, changes least

HIERARCHY → locally ranked by purity and pollution

MECHANISM

HEREDITARY MEMBERSHIP → fixed by birth

OCCUPATION LINK → weakest joint, broken by urban work

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

ENDOAMY → most consistently observed, changes least

HIERARCHY → locally ranked by purity and pollution

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: OCCUPATION LINK → weakest joint, broken by urban work.

02

STAGE 02

MARRIAGE RULES THAT OPERATE TOGETHER

MARRIAGE RULES THAT OPERATE TOGETHER

CASTE ENDOGAMY

MARRY WITHIN THE JATI

GOTRA EXOGAMY

MARRY OUTSIDE THE CLAN LINEAGE

A BOUNDED BUT NON-CONSANGUINEOUS MARRIAGE CIRCLE

CASTE IS REPRODUCED GENERATION BY GENERATION

CASTE ENDOGAMY → marry within the jati

GOTRA EXOGAMY → marry outside the clan lineage

RESULT → a bounded but non-consanguineous marriage circle

CONSEQUENCE → caste is reproduced generation by generation

CORE CLAIM	MECHANISM	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
CASTE ENDOGAMY → marry within the jati GOTRA EXOGAMY → marry outside the clan lineage	RESULT → a bounded but non-consanguineous marriage circle CONSEQUENCE → caste is reproduced generation by generation	CASTE ENDOGAMY → marry within the jati GOTRA EXOGAMY → marry outside the clan lineage

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RESULT → a bounded but non-consanguineous marriage circle.

03

STAGE 03

MOBILITY STRATEGIES

MOBILITY STRATEGIES

EMULATE A LOCALLY HIGHER-STATUS CASTE

CLAIMS RANK INSIDE THE EXISTING HIERARCHY

NEW VALUES FROM WESTERN CONTACT

CAN SUBVERT THE HIERARCHY RATHER THAN CONFIRM IT

CORE CLAIM	MECHANISM	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
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03

CORE CLAIM

- CASTE ENDOGAMY → marry within the jati
- GOTRA EXOGAMY → marry outside the clan lineage

MECHANISM

- RESULT → a bounded but non-consanguineous marriage circle
- CONSEQUENCE → caste is reproduced generation by generation

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- CASTE ENDOGAMY → marry within the jati
- GOTRA EXOGAMY → marry outside the clan lineage

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RESULT → a bounded but non-consanguineous marriage circle.

04

STAGE 03

MOBILITY STRATEGIES

MOBILITY STRATEGIES

EMULATE A LOCALLY HIGHER-STATUS CASTE

CLAIMS RANK INSIDE THE EXISTING HIERARCHY

NEW VALUES FROM WESTERN CONTACT

CAN SUBVERT THE HIERARCHY RATHER THAN CONFIRM IT

CORE CLAIM	MECHANISM	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
SANSKRITISATION → emulate a locally higher-status caste	WESTERNISATION → new values from Western contact	SANSKRITISATION → emulate a locally higher-status caste
EFFECT → claims rank inside the existing hierarchy	EFFECT → can subvert the hierarchy rather than confirm it	EFFECT → claims rank inside the existing hierarchy

CORE CLAIM

- SANSKRITISATION → emulate a locally higher-status caste
- EFFECT → claims rank inside the existing hierarchy

MECHANISM

- WESTERNISATION → new values from Western contact
- EFFECT → can subvert the hierarchy rather than confirm it

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- SANSKRITISATION → emulate a locally higher-status caste
- EFFECT → claims rank inside the existing hierarchy

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: EFFECT → can subvert the hierarchy rather than confirm it.

05

STAGE 04

DOMINANT CASTE TEST

DOMINANT CASTE TEST

IS THE CASTE LOCALLY NUMEROUS

DOES IT HOLD A SIGNIFICANT SHARE OF LOCAL LAND

DOES IT CONTROL POLITICAL AND PANCHAYAT POSITIONS

DOMINANCE CAN SIT BELOW THE RITUAL TOP

NUMBERS → is the caste locally numerous

LAND → does it hold a significant share of local land

OFFICE → does it control political and Panchayat positions

VERDICT → dominance can sit below the ritual top

CORE CLAIM	MECHANISM	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
NUMBERS → is the caste locally numerous	OFFICE → does it control political and Panchayat positions	NUMBERS → is the caste locally numerous
LAND → does it hold a significant share of local land	VERDICT → dominance can sit below the ritual top	LAND → does it hold a significant share of local land

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT → dominance can sit below the ritual top.

06

STAGE 05

CASTE AND CLASS

CASTE AND CLASS

CASTE RANK AND ECONOMIC CLASS COINCIDE LOCALLY

RICH AND POOR HOUSEHOLDS INSIDE ONE CASTE

URBAN EMPLOYMENT AND MARKET CREDENTIALS

THE OVERLAP IS LOOSENING, NOT ABOLISHED

CORE CLAIM	MECHANISM	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
OVERLAP → caste rank and economic class coincide locally	DRIVER → urban employment and market credentials	OVERLAP → caste rank and economic class coincide locally
CROSS-CUTTING → rich and poor households inside one caste	LIMIT → the overlap is loosening, not abolished	CROSS-CUTTING → rich and poor households inside one caste

CORE CLAIM

- OVERLAP → caste rank and economic class coincide locally
- CROSS-CUTTING → rich and poor households inside one caste

MECHANISM

- DRIVER → urban employment and market credentials
- LIMIT → the overlap is loosening, not abolished

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- OVERLAP → caste rank and economic class coincide locally
- CROSS-CUTTING → rich and poor households inside one caste

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: LIMIT → the overlap is loosening, not abolished.

STAGE 06

ASSOCIATIONAL REINVENTION

ASSOCIATIONAL REINVENTION

OCCUPATIONAL ALLOCATION AND PUBLIC PURITY ENFORCEMENT

REPLACED BY

CASTE ASSOCIATIONS, TRUSTS AND ELECTORAL BLOCS

ENDOGAMY AND INTIMATE-SPHERE DISCRIMINATION

CHANGE OF REGISTER, NOT DISAPPEARANCE

WEAKENED → occupational allocation and public purity enforcement

REPLACED BY → caste associations, trusts and electoral blocs

UNCHANGED → endogamy and intimate-sphere discrimination

VERDICT → change of register, not disappearance

CORE CLAIM	MECHANISM	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
WEAKENED → occupational allocation and public purity enforcement	UNCHANGED → endogamy and intimate-sphere discrimination	WEAKENED → occupational allocation and public purity enforcement

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: LIMIT → the overlap is loosening, not abolished.

STAGE 06 ASSOCIATIONAL REINVENTION

ASSOCIATIONAL REINVENTION OCCUPATIONAL ALLOCATION AND PUBLIC PURITY ENFORCEMENT REPLACED BY CASTE ASSOCIATIONS, TRUSTS AND ELECTORAL BLOCS ENDOGAMY AND INTIMATE-SPHERE DISCRIMINATION CHANGE OF REGISTER, NOT DISAPPEARANCE

WEAKENED → occupational allocation and public purity enforcement → REPLACED BY → caste associations, trusts and electoral blocs → UNCHANGED → endogamy and intimate-sphere discrimination → VERDICT → change of register, not disappearance

CORE CLAIM

- WEAKENED → occupational allocation and public purity enforcement
- REPLACED BY → caste associations, trusts and electoral blocs

MECHANISM

- UNCHANGED → endogamy and intimate-sphere discrimination
- VERDICT → change of register, not disappearance

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- WEAKENED → occupational allocation and public purity enforcement
- REPLACED BY → caste associations, trusts and electoral blocs

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: REPLACED BY → caste associations, trusts and electoral blocs.

STAGE 07 FLUID AND STATIC RESOLVED BY LEVEL

FLUID AND STATIC RESOLVED BY LEVEL STATIC LAYER ENDOGAMY, HEREDITARY MEMBERSHIP, SEGREGATION FLUID LAYER RANK CLAIMS, DOMINANCE, MARKET MOBILITY RANK IS LOCALLY CONSTRUCTED, BOUNDARY IS MARITAL THE PARADOX IS A LEVEL DISTINCTION, NOT A CONTRADICTION

CORE CLAIM

- STATIC LAYER → endogamy, hereditary membership, segregation
- FLUID LAYER → rank claims, dominance, market mobility

MECHANISM

- WHY → rank is locally constructed, boundary is marital
- ANSWER → the paradox is a level distinction, not a contradiction

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- STATIC LAYER → endogamy, hereditary membership, segregation
- FLUID LAYER → rank claims, dominance, market mobility

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: ANSWER → the paradox is a level distinction, not a contradiction.

STAGE 08 IDENTITY AXES BY ARENA

IDENTITY AXES BY ARENA JATI AND SUB-JATI DECIDE THE BOUNDARY SHRINE AND DEVOTION SECT THROUGH DOCTRINE AND LINEAGE ELECTORAL MOBILISATION JATI CLUSTERS AND RELIGION DEVELOPMENT GRIEVANCE REGION AND LANGUAGE

CORE CLAIM

MARRIAGE → jati and sub-jati decide the boundary
SHRINE AND DEVOTION → sect through doctrine and lineage

MECHANISM

ELECTORAL MOBILISATION → jati clusters and religion
DEVELOPMENT GRIEVANCE → region and language

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

MARRIAGE → jati and sub-jati decide the boundary
SHRINE AND DEVOTION → sect through doctrine and lineage

CORE CLAIM

- MARRIAGE → jati and sub-jati decide the boundary
- SHRINE AND DEVOTION → sect through doctrine and lineage

MECHANISM

- ELECTORAL MOBILISATION → jati clusters and religion
- DEVELOPMENT GRIEVANCE → region and language

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- MARRIAGE → jati and sub-jati decide the boundary
- SHRINE AND DEVOTION → sect through doctrine and lineage

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: SHRINE AND DEVOTION → sect through doctrine and lineage.

STAGE 09 TWO MARRIAGE BOUNDARIES

TWO MARRIAGE BOUNDARIES PARITY PROTECTS STATUS AND RESOURCE BASE BELONGING, KINSHIP AND COMMUNITY SANCTION CIVIL ROUTE SPECIAL MARRIAGE ACT, 1954 EXISTS ACROSS RELIGIONS DIFFERENT GUARDS, THEREFORE DIFFERENT SPEEDS CLOSE DISTINCTION

VARNA IS NOT JATI, CASTE IS NOT CLASS, RITUAL

CORE CLAIM

INTERCASTE → parity protects status and resource base
INTERRELIGIOUS → belonging, kinship and community sanction
CIVIL ROUTE → Special Marriage Act, 1954 exists across religions

MECHANISM

VERDICT → different guards, therefore different speeds
CLOSE DISTINCTION: Varna is not jati, caste is not class, ritual rank is not
identical to economic or political power, untouchability is not every caste inequality, and constitutional

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

Scheduled Caste status is a legal-administrative category rather than a complete sociological map.

CORE CLAIM

- INTERCASTE → parity protects status and resource base
- INTERRELIGIOUS → belonging, kinship and community sanction
- CIVIL ROUTE → Special Marriage Act, 1954 exists across religions

MECHANISM

- VERDICT → different guards, therefore different speeds
- CLOSE DISTINCTION: Varna is not jati, caste is not class, ritual rank is not
- identical to economic or political power, untouchability is not every caste inequality, and constitutional

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- Scheduled Caste status is a legal-administrative category rather than a complete sociological map.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE DISTINCTION: Varna is not jati, caste is not class, ritual rank is not identical to economic or political power, untouchability is not every caste inequality, and constitutional Scheduled Caste status is a legal-administrative category rather than a complete sociological map.

INTERCASTE → parity protects status and resource base

INTERRELIGIOUS → belonging, kinship and community sanction

CIVIL ROUTE → Special Marriage Act, 1954 exists across religions

CORE CLAIM

- INTERCASTE → parity protects status and resource base
- INTERRELIGIOUS → belonging, kinship and community sanction
- CIVIL ROUTE → Special Marriage Act, 1954 exists across religions

MECHANISM

- VERDICT → different guards, therefore different speeds
- CLOSE DISTINCTION: Varna is not jati, caste is not class, ritual rank is not identical to economic or political power, untouchability is not every caste inequality, and constitutional

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- Scheduled Caste status is a legal-administrative category rather than a complete sociological map.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE DISTINCTION: Varna is not jati, caste is not class, ritual rank is not identical to economic or political power, untouchability is not every caste inequality, and constitutional Scheduled Caste status is a legal-administrative category rather than a complete sociological map.

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STAGE 10

MEASUREMENT STATUS

MEASUREMENT STATUS

PIB 30 APRIL 2025

CASTE ENUMERATION ANNOUNCED FOR CENSUS 2027

GAZETTE S.O. 2681(E)

FIXES THE REFERENCE DATES

PROSPECTIVE, SO NO CASTE COUNT MAY BE QUOTED

NOT INDIA'S FIRST HISTORICAL CASTE ENUMERATION

EVIDENCE LIMIT

CORE CLAIM

PIB 30 APRIL 2025 → caste enumeration announced for Census 2027

GAZETTE S.O. 2681(E) → fixes the reference dates

STATUS → prospective, so no caste count may be quoted

MECHANISM

LIMIT → not India's first historical caste enumeration

EVIDENCE LIMIT: Articles 15-17, 46, 330-342A and reservation institutions set legal boundaries, but legal prohibition does not equal

compare Jat, Maratha,

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

Patidar, Dalit and regional caste dynamics without homogenising communities or inferring causes from aggregate correlations.

CORE CLAIM

- PIB 30 APRIL 2025 → caste enumeration announced for Census 2027
- GAZETTE S.O. 2681(E) → fixes the reference dates
- STATUS → prospective, so no caste count may be quoted

MECHANISM

- LIMIT → not India's first historical caste enumeration
- EVIDENCE LIMIT: Articles 15-17, 46, 330-342A and reservation institutions set legal boundaries, but legal prohibition does not equal
- compare Jat, Maratha,

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- Patidar, Dalit and regional caste dynamics without homogenising communities or inferring causes from aggregate correlations.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Patidar, Dalit and regional caste dynamics without homogenising communities or inferring causes from aggregate correlations.

11

STAGE 11

CASTE ANSWER SPINE

CASTE ANSWER SPINE

NAME THE LEVEL AND THE DEMAND FAMILY

STRUCTURE, MOBILITY, DOMINANCE, ASSOCIATION

WHAT CHANGED AGAINST WHAT DID NOT

ARENA-SPECIFIC VERDICT WITH THE MEASUREMENT CAVEAT

OPEN → name the level and the demand family

BODY → structure, mobility, dominance, association

TENSION → what changed against what did not

CLOSE → arena-specific verdict with the measurement caveat

CORE CLAIM

- OPEN → name the level and the demand family
- BODY → structure, mobility, dominance, association

MECHANISM

- TENSION → what changed against what did not
- CLOSE → arena-specific verdict with the measurement caveat

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- OPEN → name the level and the demand family
- BODY → structure, mobility, dominance, association

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE → arena-specific verdict with the measurement caveat.

E

EXTRA

SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT

CASTE ASSOCIATIONS AS POLITICAL INTERMEDIARIES

JATI-LEVEL BODIES INCREASINGLY

CASTE-CENSUS DEBATE (SOCIOLOGICAL, NOT ENUMERATION-METHODOLOGY)

DEMANDS FOR

RESERVATION AS A STRUCTURAL RESPONSE (CROSS-LINKED, NOT RESTATED)

URBAN CASTE PERSISTENCE

EVEN WHERE RITUAL PRACTICES WEAKEN, CASTE-BASED NETWORKS

OPTIONAL SOURCE DEPTH

- CAUTION: Caste associations as political intermediaries: jati-level bodies increasingly
- CAUTION: Caste-census debate (sociological, not enumeration-methodology): demands for
- Reservation as a structural response (cross-linked, not restated): constitutional
- CAUTION: Urban caste persistence: even where ritual practices weaken, caste-based networks

ADVANCED DEBATE

- CAUTION: Boundary case 1: a Sanskritising jati that gains ritual respectability but remains
- CAUTION: Boundary case 2: a numerically dominant but ritually middling caste controlling a
- CAUTION: Boundary case 3: an intercaste marriage between two economically equal
- CAUTION: Sanskritisation's ceiling: emulation can raise local ritual standing but cannot by

LEGACY / NUANCE

- CAUTION: Marriage-trend generalisation risk: the 2024 PYQ's trend (rising intercaste,
- M.N. Srinivas developed both Sanskritisation and dominant caste from his Rampura
- Dominant caste is defined by numbers + land + political power, independent of ritual
- Sanskritisation operates within the existing hierarchy; Westernisation introduces

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.